

AUGUST 27, 1776 · AUGUST 27, 2026

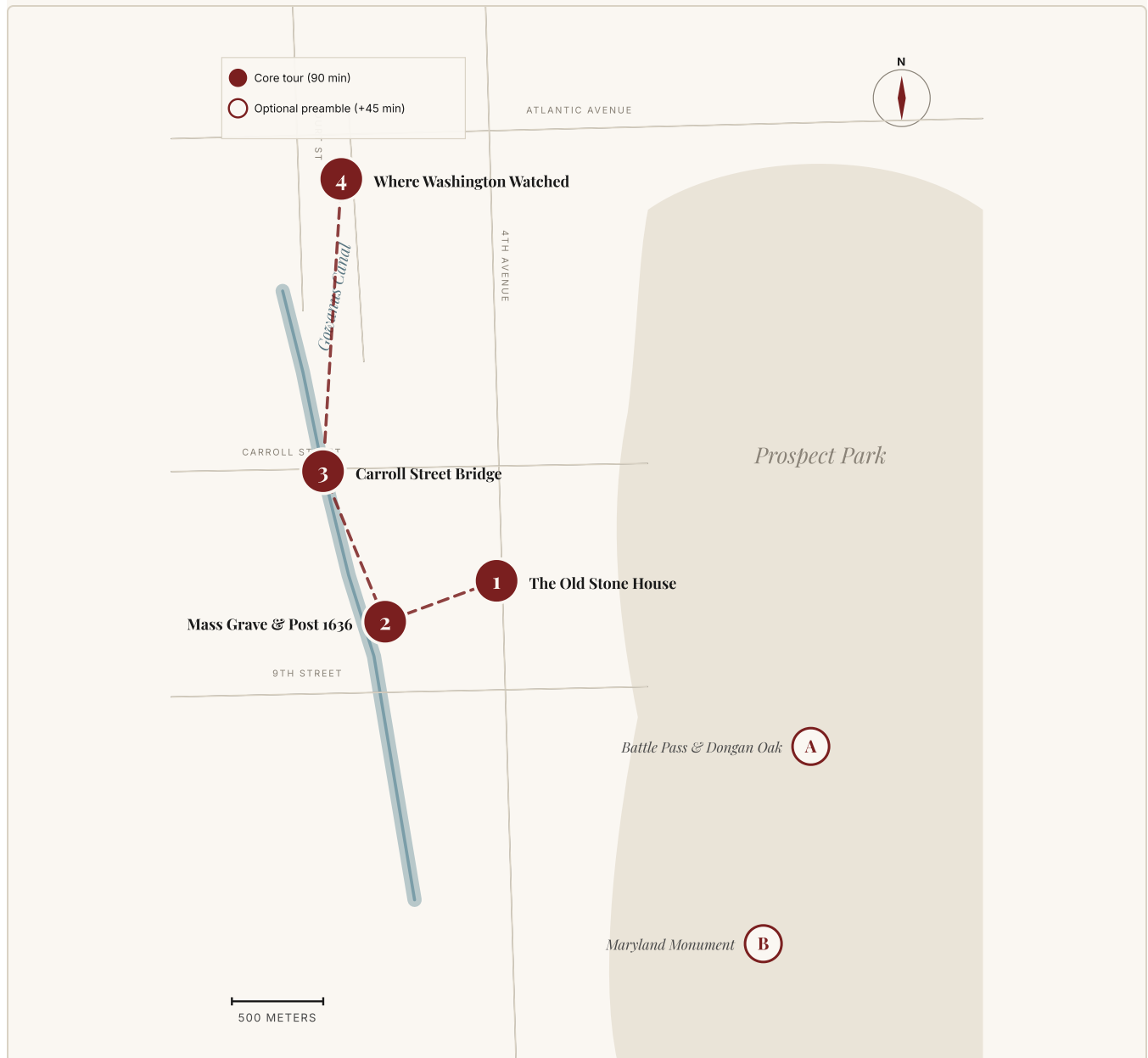
The Battle of Brooklyn, 250 Years Later

One of the most consequential battles of the entire Revolutionary War, and its largest, was fought here.

A self-guided walking tour of four sites in the Gowanus area where the war was fought and where its heroes are buried. The walk runs about 90 minutes over flat ground, ending where George Washington watched his army nearly destroyed.

The Route

Four stops, in order, covering about a mile and a half of mostly flat ground. Two optional sites in Prospect Park for the longer version.



OPTIONAL · ADDS 45 MINUTES

Prospect Park Preamble

If you want the longer version, start in Prospect Park where the battle began at dawn. Two extra stops, then walk west to the Old Stone House to pick up the core tour.

Battle Pass & the Dongan Oak

East Drive at Battle Pass, Prospect Park

In the predawn hours of August 27, 1776, British and Hessian forces under General Henry Clinton flanked the American line by marching all night through the unguarded Jamaica Pass to the east. They hit the Americans here at first light, from behind.

As the British advanced, American soldiers felled the massive Dongan Oak, the boundary tree of an old colonial estate, to try to slow them down. It did not work. The Dongan Oak Monument stands here today commemorating the tree and the failed last-ditch defense.

The Maryland Monument

Prospect Park, near the 9th Street entrance

A 12-foot granite column topped with a marble orb, erected in 1895 by the Society of Old Brooklynites to honor the Maryland 400. It is the official memorial to the soldiers whose sacrifice the rest of this tour walks through.

The monument is being rededicated on August 22, 2026, as part of the 250th anniversary commemoration. Stand here a minute. Then begin the walk west. The Old Stone House is 20 minutes away.

1 The Old Stone House

336 3rd Street · J.J. Byrne Playground

TODAY A small stone building inside a public playground. Free museum. The flagship 250th exhibit, *The Battle of Brooklyn: Fought and Remembered*, runs through December 31, 2026.

THEN The Cortelyou House. The position the Maryland 400 charged six times.

By late morning on August 27, 1776, the American line had collapsed. Washington's army was retreating northwest toward the Gowanus marsh, trying to reach the fortifications in Brooklyn Heights. They were going to be slaughtered if someone did not slow the British down.

The Maryland 1st Regiment, about 400 men under Lord Stirling, turned around. They charged Cornwallis's position at the Cortelyou House, the building standing next to you now. They charged six times. They knew they were going to lose.

While the Maryland 1st Regiment fought, the rest of Washington's army waded through the salt marsh that is now the Gowanus Canal. Without the Maryland 1st Regiment, the army does not escape.

Of the 400 men who turned to fight, only around 10 made it back to American lines. 256 died on this ground. The rest were wounded or captured. From the high ground at Cobble Hill, Washington watched and said, *"Good God, what brave fellows I must this day lose."*

WALK TO STOP 2 · ABOUT 15 MINUTES

Exit the park on the Fourth Avenue side and take a left. Walk to Ninth Street and take a right heading toward Third Avenue. Our next stop is where the Marylanders were buried.

2 The Mass Grave & Post 1636

3rd Avenue and 9th Street · Post 1636 at 193 9th Street

TODAY

An American Legion post and the lot beside it. A historic marker. Almost nobody who walks past it knows what is underneath.

THEN

The burial site of the 256 Maryland soldiers killed at the Old Stone House.

The 256 Maryland soldiers killed at the Old Stone House are believed to be buried here, in the lot at the corner of 3rd and 9th, adjacent to American Legion Post 1636 (the Michael A. Rawley Post). A New York State historic marker on the site explains the story.

The exact location of the grave has been debated for almost 250 years. A 2017 archaeological dig at a nearby site on 9th Street found no human remains, and historians now think the soldiers may have been buried in scattered locations across the area rather than in a single mass grave. The uncertainty is part of why this corner has mattered for so long: an unmarked place of rest, contested by time, defended by neighbors.

What is not in dispute is who has kept the memory alive on this corner. Post 1636 has tended this ground since 1962, holding a ceremony every August and fighting to keep the lot from being developed over. The Post and its members are the reason this story has not been forgotten.

WALK TO STOP 3 · ABOUT 10 MINUTES

Walk north on 3rd Avenue. Turn left on Carroll Street. The bridge is just past Nevins Street, on your way to the canal.

3 Carroll Street Bridge

Carroll Street between Bond and Nevins

TODAY	One of only four retractile bridges left in the United States. On the National Register of Historic Places. Built in 1889.
THEN	A salt marsh several hundred yards wide. Washington's army waded across it to escape.

The Gowanus Creek in 1776 was a salt marsh several hundred yards across in places, broken by tidal channels and soft mud that gave way under a man's weight. It was treacherous to cross on foot under any conditions, and conditions that afternoon were not good. While the Maryland 400 were dying at the Old Stone House, the rest of Washington's army was wading through this water, weighed down by muskets and packs, with British and Hessian fire at their backs. Some drowned. Most made it.

The Carroll Street Bridge sits roughly across the line they would have taken. What you see today as a canal is what remains of that marsh, narrowed and channeled by a century of industrial dredging and fill, but running along the same path.

Stand on the bridge a minute. Look north toward the downtown Brooklyn skyline. Further to the west of that skyline is the high ground the army was trying to reach. From here, they made it.

WALK TO STOP 4 · ABOUT 17 MINUTES

Continue across the bridge. Turn right on Bond Street. Walk two blocks north and take a left on Union Street. Follow Union Street for two blocks and take a right onto Smith Street. Take a left on Atlantic Avenue and head to Court Street. The Trader Joe's on the corner is your next stop.

4 Where Washington Watched

130 Court Street at Atlantic Avenue · the Trader Joe's

TODAY

One of the busiest grocery stores in Brooklyn, in a 1922 Florentine Renaissance former bank building. A plaque on the building. Look up at the corner.

THEN

The summit of Cobble Hill Fort, also called Smith's Barbette, or the Corkscrew Fort. Washington's observation post.

This corner used to be a steep, cone-shaped hill called Ponkiesbergh, or Cobleshill, or just Cobble Hill. On top of the hill, in the summer of 1776, the American army built a fort. After the army retreated across the East River, the British cut down its top so the position could not be used to observe their headquarters in Brooklyn Heights. What remained was leveled in the 1830s, the dirt used to fill in the marshes you just walked across.

Its official name was Smith's Barbette, after Captain William Smith, the army engineer who built it. British soldiers called it the Corkscrew Fort, because of the spiral road that wound up the hill to move cannon to its top. Earlier that summer, Washington had ordered that two cannon shots fired from this hill would be the signal that the British had landed on Long Island.

On August 27, 1776, the cannon went off. Washington came down from Manhattan. He stood on this hill alongside General Putnam and watched his army get destroyed in front of him. The Maryland 1st Regiment's stand at the Old Stone House happened in his direct line of sight. The retreat across the marsh happened in his direct line of sight. The defeat happened in his direct line of sight.

That night, the survivors climbed up to this fort and the other fortifications along the Brooklyn Heights ridge. The British, expecting an easy finish in the morning, dug in for a siege.

Two nights later, on August 29 into August 30, under cover of fog, Washington pulled off the impossible. The entire 9,000-man Continental Army, with every horse, every cannon, every wounded soldier, was evacuated across the East River to Manhattan in a single night, in small boats commandeered from Brooklyn fishermen. By dawn, the British woke to empty trenches. The army was gone.

The plaque is on the building, above eye level on the Atlantic Avenue side. Take a minute with it. From this corner, on this ground, the Revolution survived because the Maryland 1st Regiment chose the harder thing a mile to the south, and because Washington made an impossible decision two nights later from the spot you are standing on now.

AFTER

What Happened Next

Washington's army made it to Manhattan, but the war was far from over. Within weeks the British pushed the Continental Army out of New York entirely. Washington retreated across New Jersey, lost more battles, nearly lost the war. The army survived to fight Trenton on Christmas night, then Princeton, then six more years of brutal campaigning ending at Yorktown in 1781.

None of it happens if the army does not escape Brooklyn. The escape does not happen without the Maryland 1st Regiment's stand at the Old Stone House. The stand does not happen without the soldiers who chose to die rather than run.

You walked through their ground.

FOR AFTER THE WALK

The Gowanus Eating & Drinking Guide

199 restaurants, bars, coffee shops, and bakeries across the Gowanus area. Free, no paywall.

SATURDAY MORNINGS, FREE

The Gowanaut Newsletter

What is opening, changing, and worth knowing in the Gowanus area. One email a week.

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Have something to add or correct? thegowanaut@gmail.com

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